VIVEK, 23, GRADUATED with a BA degree two years ago, and has been burning the midnight oil to get a job in the police force. It has been a long, anxiety-riddled wait that was made more harrowing after an earlier exam was cancelled. Today, he works in a packaging factory in Aligarh to supplement the family income, shares a room with three young co-workers, and has enrolled himself in a part-time computer course while he prepares for more exams. "The next exam is scheduled over the next six months," he says. "I hope it takes place and I get recruited."

Vivek is the youngest child—he has two older sisters—of Rupa, a nanny, and Arvind, a driver, in Delhi. While his current job gives him a degree of financial independence, his parents are worried. "We have toiled hard for his education," says Rupa. "He still dreams of getting a police job but it's difficult for him—living away from the family, working and studying at the same time."

Vivek's plight typifies that of millions of young men and women across India. These youngsters, armed with graduate, post-graduate and even technical training degrees, are hunting desperately for work—including appearing for exams to get the coveted government jobs—in a market for which their education did not prepare them.

While regular jobs in the private sector remain difficult to get, government jobs have gotten even tougher with cancelled exams, long recruitment process and fewer appointments. And the pressure on the young to get jobs will only intensify. India's working-age population of (15+ years) is expected to exceed 980 million in the next 10 years, from 616 million at present, data from the Economic Survey 2025-26 showed.

But employment numbers underpin the story. According to the government's Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) report for August 2026, youth unemployment (15 years and above) was at 15.1%, thrice the overall unemployment of 5%. In 2025, these numbers were 9.9% and 3.1%, respectively.

A recent report by CareEdge Ratings noted this can be attributed to the persistent gap between education levels and availability of suitable employment opportunities. "Furthermore, unemployment numbers may overstate gains given rising self-employment and prevalence of disguised unemployment in agriculture. The rate may understate the extent of unemployment in an economy characterised by seasonal, casual, and irregular employment," it said.

And even for those who find work, the problem is often not solved. Indrajit, a BA graduate who currently works as a delivery partner for a food platform, is in his late 20s and actively looking for other work after he was laid off recently from a job at the Delhi airport. Life as a factory worker has little appeal for him due to its low wages. "As a delivery partner, I earn ₹700-800 per day. Many of my friends work as drivers and I am hoping to get a job like that too. I can earn at least ₹30,000 per month then," he says. To cut costs, he has stopped visiting his family, which lives near Lucknow. "I am barely managing in Delhi. Travel adds unnecessary costs," he says.

The International Labour Organization (ILO), in a recent report, said youth unemployment is rising across the world and was 12.4% in 2025 due to slowing global economic growth, diminished job creation, geopolitical tensions and rapid technological change. Job creation is not keeping pace with growth in the youth population in multiple regions.

In India, too, this phenomenon has been evident all through the year 2026, which saw youth pro-



"Employers are looking for freshers who are upskilled, have good soft skills, can communicate well, and function in a team environment"

Sashi Kumar
Managing Director, Indeed India